

GODS AND GODDESSES



SINCE PREHISTORIC TIMES, humans have worshipped gods and goddesses – spirits that are believed to control nature and human destinies. The mythology that surrounds them attempts to explain the how and why of life, and account for forces that are beyond human control. The rituals associated with these supernatural beings, or deities, are a powerful force in binding societies together. The variety of gods and goddesses worshipped around the world reflects the diversity and power of human imagination.

Gods

Much of what we know of gods and goddesses was passed down by men rather than women, so male gods – often gods of war – predominate in mythology. Many myths portray the struggle between good and evil. Some deities are kind and just, while others, such as the Norse god Loki, commit acts of evil and treachery on other gods or humans. Gods may be depicted either in human form, or as part-human and part-animal.

Thor

In Norse mythology, Thor was the god of the sky, rain, thunder, and farming. Thor's hammer, known as Mjollnir, made thunderbolts when the god threw it. Norse gods such as Thor and Odin were worshipped in parts of Scandinavia up until the 12th century.



Thor fighting frost giants



Mars was popular in Rome.

Mars

Mars, god of war, was said to be the father of Rome's founder. Many Roman gods were equivalent to earlier Greek versions: Mars was called Ares in Greek mythology, and Demeter, goddess of spring, was Persephone.



Venus figure, c.4000 BC

Mother goddess

Every culture had a mother goddess, one of the earliest deities, who represented nature and fertility. In ancient Egypt, she was called Isis and may have been a model for the Christian Madonna.



Hades and Persephone

Persephone

In Greek mythology, Hades, god of the underworld, abducts Persephone. She returns to the world for six months every year, bringing spring and summer.



Durga

In Hinduism, Durga is the powerful warrior-goddess. She is often represented with a beautiful face and 10 arms, each one holding a weapon.

Sacrifices

A sacrifice is an offering of an animal, plant, possession, or even a human life, to please or pacify a deity. In ancient cultures, sacrifices were made to gods and goddesses on special days or at important ceremonies. Ancient Romans marked such occasions with a *suovetaurilia*, a special sacrifice involving a bull, a ram, and a pig – the most valuable items of Roman livestock.



Wicker man

Roman historians recorded that Celtic tribes in Gaul (France) placed human sacrifices inside wickerwork figures, then burnt them alive. Wicker figures are still burnt at festivals in Spain.

Mountain-top sacrifice

The Aztecs offered human sacrifices to the god of the Sun, Tezcatlipoca. This deity was the most feared of the Aztec gods and thousands, usually prisoners of war, were sacrificed in his name.

The Aztecs carefully chose their victim, who was accorded great honours for one year. Then, on the day of the sacrifice, a priest cut open the victim's chest and offered his heart up to Tezcatlipoca.



Aztec warrior and his prisoner of war

Priests

In many societies, priests are the human links between the natural world and the supernatural world of the gods. They are thought to have special, often magical power, and may carry out sacred rites.



Priest in traditional costume

Priest's costume

Costumes convey authority and represent tradition. The priest's costume of the Nkimba people of the Congo, West Africa, includes an ornate carved wooden mask and a grass net decorated with feathers.



Shaman's mask

The shamans of Native American tribes wore masks representing a guardian spirit. This showed the connection between the human and spirit worlds.

Oracles

The term "oracle" describes a direct communication with a deity through the mouth of a priest. The most famous oracle was at Delphi in ancient Greece, at a temple to the god Apollo. In Greek mythology, the heroes Oedipus and Heracles consulted the oracle, whose replies to questions were always ambiguous.



Delphi Oracle, Greece

FIND OUT MORE

AZTECS

CELTS

EGYPT, ANCIENT

GREECE, ANCIENT

MAYA

RELIGIONS

ROMAN EMPIRE

WITCHES AND WITCHCRAFT